

# If You Don't Build It, ★ They Will Still Come

Page 1  
of 8



## The Post-Construction Economy and the Triumph of Vaporware as a Service

### Abstract

This paper investigates a fundamental inversion in the **relationship between product existence and market capitalization**. We document the transition from the classical "Field of Dreams" paradigm (if you build it, they will come) to the contemporary "Phantom Stadium" model (if you pretend to build it, perform sufficient reality distortion, and hire the right marketing team, they will come anyway—and pay in advance).

Through analysis of cryptocurrency white papers, AI product announcements, and the Metaverse Industrial Complex, we demonstrate that actual construction has become optional in modern economics. What matters is not the artifact, but the Aspirational Narrative Density (AND) surrounding its hypothetical future existence.

We term this phenomenon **Vaporware Supremacy**—the structural advantage gained by not building the thing while maintaining maximum hype velocity.

### KEY INSIGHT:

In modern markets, ★  
**BELIEF** scales.  
**BUILDING** does not.

WE SELL  
TOMORROWS.  
(WE DELIVER  
MAYBES.)

### 1. Introduction: The Evolutionary Pressures Against Completion

#### 1.1 The 1990s Paradigm: "Build It and They Will Come"

The late 20th century operated under a quaint assumption:

- Create a good product
- Launch it to the public
- Allow merit to generate demand

**The Constraint:** You had to actually build something.

**The Risk:** People could evaluate whether it worked.

**The Fatal Flaw:** If it failed, you were exposed.

#### 1.2 The 2020s Paradigm: "Don't Build It, They'll Come Anyway"

Modern economics has evolved beyond this primitive requirement.

**The Innovation:** Monetize the anticipation of the product, not the product itself.

**The Advantage:** No one can evaluate something that doesn't exist.

**The Genius:** Failure is impossible because completion never occurred.

We formalize this as the **Perpetual Pre-Release Paradox (PPP)**:

$$\text{Value} = \left( \text{Hype} \times \frac{\text{Time Until Launch}}{\text{Actual Functionality}} \right)$$

As functionality  $\rightarrow 0$ , and time until launch  $\rightarrow \infty$ , Value  $\rightarrow \infty$ .

**BUILDING IS OPTIONAL. HYPE IS COMPOUNDING. THE FUTURE IS PRE-RELEASE.**



# 2. Case Studies in Strategic Non-Construction



## 2.1 The Metaverse: A \$100 Billion Rendering Error

- Announced:** 2021
- Budget Allocated:** \$100+ billion
- Status as of 2025:** A series of uncanny valley avatars in empty conference rooms



**The Brilliance:** Meta successfully convinced investors to fund a virtual world by showing them concept art of a virtual world.



### The Method:

- Produce high-quality CGI trailers
- Feature avatars doing impossible things (teleporting, defying physics, having fun)
- Never show actual gameplay
- Pivot terminology when questioned ("It's not a game, it's a persistent digital reality")



**The Result:** Billions in funding for a product that, even when "launched," resembled a 2003 chatroom with worse graphics.



**Key Insight:** The target audience wasn't users—it was shareholders who don't use computers.



## 2.2 Cryptocurrency: The Infinite White Paper

### The Traditional Economy:

- Create a service
- Users pay for service
- Service must function



### The Crypto Economy:

- Write a white paper
- Users pay for future hypothetical service
- Service remains perpetually "in development"



### The Evolution:

| Year | Promise                            | Delivered                          |
|------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 2017 | "Banking the unbanked"             | JPEGs of apes                      |
| 2021 | "Decentralized finance revolution" | Ponzi schemes with better branding |
| 2023 | "Real-world utility"               | More white papers                  |
| 2025 | "AGI on blockchain"                | Still just white papers            |

**The Genius:** Each failed promise generates a new white paper, creating an infinite funding loop.



### The Formula:

$$ICO_n = \text{White Paper}_n + \text{Expired Promises}_{(n-1)}$$

Where each iteration resets expectations without delivering prior commitments.



IF YOU CAN'T BUILD IT, BRAND IT. IF YOU CAN'T BRAND IT, FUND IT ANYWAY.





## 2.3 AI Product Launches: The Announced-But-Unavailable Framework



### Traditional Software Release:

1. Build the software
2. Test it
3. Release it
4. Users evaluate it

### Modern AI Release:

1. Announce revolutionary breakthrough
2. Show cherry-picked demos
3. Release to "limited beta" (10 people)
4. Generate 10,000 news articles about what it could do
5. Delay general release indefinitely
6. Announce the next version before releasing current version

### Example Timeline:

- March 2024: "GPT-5 will revolutionize everything"
- June 2024: "Actually we're focusing on GPT-4.5"
- September 2024: "GPT-4.5 is amazing but not ready"
- December 2024: "Announcing GPT-5 architecture paper"
- March 2025: "GPT-5 coming soon, but check out GPT-6 roadmap"



**The Pattern:** Each announcement obsoletes the previous promise before delivery.



**The Advantage:** You're always selling the future, never defending the present.

**HYPE** IS THE NEW PRODUCT. **ACCESS** IS THE NEW SCARCITY.



# 3. The Mechanics of Strategic Non-Delivery



## 3.1 The Announcement Cascade

We identify five stages of the modern non-product lifecycle:

### 1 Stage 1: The Visionary Reveal

- Charismatic founder on stage
- Impossible claims delivered with absolute confidence
- Concept video showing what AI/physics/economics cannot yet do
- Audience gasps appropriately



### 2 Stage 2: The Strategic Vagueness

- Coming soon
- Rolling out gradually
- Invite-only beta
- Dependent on regulatory approval



### 3 Stage 3: The Pivot

- Original promise quietly abandoned
- New, adjacent promise introduced
- Original investors told "this is even better"
- New investors told "this was always the plan"



### 4 Stage 4: The Blame Externalization

- Regulatory headwinds
- Market wasn't ready
- Users didn't understand the vision
- Never:** "We couldn't build it"



### 5 Stage 5: The Resurrection

- Wait 18 months
- Announce the same product with a new name
- Claim revolutionary breakthrough
- Return to Stage 1



**Critical Insight:** Completion is the enemy of monetization.

## 3.2 The Reality Distortion Budget

Modern non-products require significant investment in the appearance of progress.

### Budget Allocation for Vaporware:

| Category            | % of Budget | Purpose                             |
|---------------------|-------------|-------------------------------------|
| Marketing           | 40%         | Generate belief                     |
| PR/Media            | 25%         | Control narrative                   |
| Demo Production     | 20%         | Create illusion of functionality    |
| Legal (NDAs, terms) | 10%         | Prevent disclosure of non-existence |
| Actual Development  | 5%          | Optional                            |

### The Math:

If you spend \$100M on marketing a product that doesn't exist, and raise \$500M based on the marketing, you've created \$400M in value from nothing.

$$\begin{array}{r} \$100M \\ + \$500M \\ \hline \$400M \end{array}$$

Traditional economics calls this **fraud**.

Modern economics calls it **pre-seed valuation optimization**.



# 4. The Cognitive Mechanisms: Why It Works

Page 5  
of 8

IT'S GOING TO  
CHANGE EVERYTHING.

I BELIEVE IN  
THE VISION.

I'M EARLY.  
I'LL WIN.

TOLD MY FRIENDS.  
NO TURNING BACK.

SOMEDAY™  
VERSION ∞

FUTURE  
VERSION  
→  
ALWAYS  
BETTER  
→

PRE-ORDER  
RECEIPT

VIP  
TOKEN

WAITLIST  
#847,321

CAN'T WAIT  
FOR THIS!

THIS WAY TO  
TOMORROWS  
(THAT NEVER COME)  
→

LINE STARTS HERE.  
LOGIC ENDS HERE. →

## 4.1 The Sunk Cost Amplifier

Once someone has:

- Pre-ordered
- Bought tokens
- Joined the waitlist
- Told friends about it



They become invested in the narrative, not the product.



- **The Trap:** Admitting it doesn't exist means admitting they were fooled.



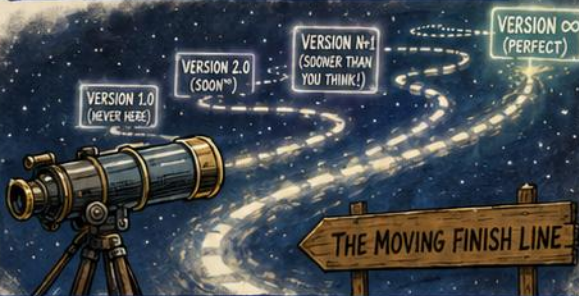
• **The Solution:** Continue believing, thereby protecting ego.



• **The Result:** A self-sustaining belief system independent of reality.

We term this **Narrative Capture**: when the story becomes more real than the thing.

## 4.2 The Infinite Future Horizon



★ **Traditional Product:** "Here it is, judge it now"

★ **Vaporware Product:** "Imagine what it will be"

★ **The Advantage:** The future is always perfect.

★ **The Method:** Every critique is met with "wait for the next version."

★ **The Genius:** There is always a next version to wait for.

★ **The Formula:**

**Criticism Deflection** = "That's being addressed in Version\_(n+1)"

Where n is always the current non-existent version.

JUST  
WAIT FOR  
VERSION  
N+7!



## 4.3 The FOMO Acceleration Engine

Scarcity is manufactured not through limited supply, but through limited access to the non-existent thing.

**The Tactic:**

- Exclusive beta access
- Founding member perks
- Early adopter pricing
- Waitlist of 2 million people



**The Reality:** There's nothing to access, so scarcity is infinite and costless.



**The Psychology:** People pay more for the promise of being first than for the actual product.



HYPE IS INTANGIBLE. PSYCHOLOGY IS REAL.



# 5. The Institutional Enablers ☆

Page 6 of 8

## 5.1 VC Funding: Betting on Narratives, Not Products

### Traditional VC Due Diligence:

- Does the product work?
- Is there a market?
- Can they execute?

### Modern VC Due Diligence:

- Is the story compelling?
- Can we flip it to the next round?
- Does the founder look good on camera?

**The Shift:** VCs don't fund products—they fund stories about potential products that can be sold to larger VCs.

**The Chain:** Founder → Angel (story) → Seed (bigger story) → Series A (even bigger story) → IPO (maximum story) → Bagholders (reality)



## 5.2 Media Complicity: The Hype-Industrial Complex

**Old Journalism:** "Is this real?"

**New Journalism:** "This could revolutionize everything"

**The Incentive:** Clicks come from excitement, not skepticism.

### The Method:

- Uncritical regurgitation of press releases
- Could, might, potentially doing heavy lifting
- No follow-up when promises evaporate
- Founder gets profiled in Wired, Forbes, TechCrunch



### The Pattern:

**2021:** "This startup will disrupt everything"

**2022:** "Why this startup's pivot shows genius"

**2023:** "Lessons from this startup's quiet shutdown"

**2024:** No mention ever again

**HYPE NEWS 24/7**



**BREAKING: STARTUP RAISES \$100M TO MAYBE DO SOMETHING**



## 6. The Ultimate Example: The National Debt Solution

**Remember the A-Political Reality Dive (APRD)?**  
The proposal to solve the national debt by finding a digital artifact in a video game?  
 That was satire.

But consider: Multiple cryptocurrency projects have raised billions by claiming they will:

- Bank the unbanked
- Democratize finance
- Create digital nations
- Solve inflation



**None have delivered.**  
**All still have market caps.**



**REALITY DIFFICULTY: IMPOSSIBLE**



**The Lesson:** The APRD isn't absurd—it's just slightly more honest about being a narrative-driven non-solution.



# 7. The Paradox of Completion

Page 7  
of 8

## 7.1 Why Building It Is Actually Bad Business



### If you build it:

- ❌ People can evaluate it
- ❌ It might fail
- ❌ You have to maintain it
- ❌ Competitors can copy it
- ❌ Reality intrudes

### If you don't build it:

- ✅ Criticism is always "premature"
- ✅ Failure is impossible
- ✅ Maintenance costs zero
- ✅ Competition is against imagination
- ✅ Reality never intrudes



### The Math:

$$ROI_{\text{vaporware}} = \frac{\text{Hype Revenue}}{\text{Development Cost}} = \frac{\$500\text{M}}{\$0} = \infty$$

$$ROI_{\text{actual product}} = \frac{\text{Sales Revenue}}{\text{Development Cost}} = \frac{\$50\text{M}}{\$40\text{M}} = 1.25$$

Conclusion: Building things is financially irrational.

## 8. Conclusion: The Post-Product Economy

We have successfully transitioned from an economy based on things that exist to one based on narratives about things that might exist eventually maybe.

### The Evolution:

1990s: "If you build it, they will come"

2000s: "Build it fast, iterate later"

2010s: "Launch MVP, scale if it works"

2020s: "Announce it, raise money, never build it"

2030s (predicted):  
"Just the announcement is the product"

### WELCOME TO THE FUTURE THAT DOESN'T EXIST YET!



The Final Form: Pure narrative capitalism, where money flows toward the idea of value without ever requiring value to manifest.



The Genius: Kevin Costner built an entire baseball field for ghosts.



Modern founders skip the field and just sell tickets to the ghosts.



The Punchline: The ghosts still show up.

They're called **investors**.

REALITY IS HARD. IMAGINATION IS MARGINABLE.

PRE-RELEASE IS PEACE.



# ★ Thanks for Attending ★ The Greatest Study Never Built!

Page 8  
of 8

★ INVESTORS  
NEVER DIE  
THEY COMPOUND!

PUBLIC  
ACCESS  
FUTURES  
CHANNEL 23

TODAY'S  
BIG NOTHING  
TOMORROW'S  
EVERYTHING!

HYPE CAM  
3000

REC  
BELIEVE  
HARDER

FIN.

GO-TO-MARKET  
EVENTUALLY

METaverse  
STRATEGY

SYNERGY  
BY DESIGN

DE-CENTRALIZED  
EVERYTHING

PARADIGM  
SHIFT

AI DISRUPTION  
ROADMAP

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY:  
SOMETHING EPIC\*

\* PROBABLY

WEB3  
VISION

TAM =  
ALL OF IT

VISION  
FUND  
FUE

INFINITE  
BETA  
BRO.

ROI  
LOL

FUELING  
DISRUPTION  
SINCE YESTERDAY

PIZZA

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- ★ Crypto projects that promised 2018 delivery in 2017
- ★ AI companies announcing products that launched "soon" three years ago
- ★ The Field of Dreams, for accidentally predicting modern economics

## References

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4. Theranos Inc. (2003-2018). *The Original Blueprint*.

## Final Note:

This paper was written entirely without building a research lab, conducting experiments, or peer review.

If you found it convincing anyway, you've proven the thesis.

BUILDING  
IS OPTIONAL.  
HYPE IS  
COMPOUNDING.

# ★ End of Poster Series ★

SEE YOU IN  
THE NEXT  
PARADIGM!

